

ಬಾಷಾ

B A S H A

a romantic drama

Final Draft

A NOTE ON SURI

Before this story starts, a word about the third wheel. SURI is a beat-up old mouth organ that lives in Arjun's shirt pocket, permanently. He doesn't get played – not for most of the film. He doesn't need to be. He talks plenty on his own.

Whenever the humans on screen go quiet – which, with our hero, is often – Suri turns straight to camera and fills the gap, talking to the audience in casual, everyday Telugu (translated underneath for the rest of us). He's loud, thinks very highly of himself, and is convinced he's the real lead of this film. He will remind you, unasked, that he's been rehearsing his solo for years now and this movie still hasn't given him the spotlight he clearly deserves.

He's not magic. He's not a ghost. He's a mouth organ with main-character energy, and the film just lets him have it.

SCENE 1 – THE PLACE

EXT. OLD LAKE / HILLTOP / QUIET STREET – EVENING

The wind moves slow through the trees. A couple of birds cut across an orange sky. Somewhere far off, the city hums.

ARJUN, 22, sits alone on a bench. Not sad. Not happy. Just someone who genuinely likes his own company.

Same road. Same trees. Same sunset. Every evening, like clockwork.

He pulls out a small notebook, writes a line, shuts it. Looks up at the sky. Smiles to himself, just a little.

The silence sits a beat too long – apparently, for someone in his pocket.

SURI (V.O.)

(in Telugu, to camera)

Vaadu maatladaadu kada... nenu maatladaathanu. Ade naa jeevitham.

[He doesn't talk, so someone's gotta. That's basically my whole job in life.]

A battered little mouth organ pokes into frame from Arjun's shirt pocket.

SURI (TO CAMERA)

Peru Suri. Prathi prema kathalo nenu heroine kanna ekkuva important vaadini, kaani ee nijam evariki teliyadu. Ippudu chudu naa paristhithi – maatladani vaadi jebi lo padi unnaanu.

[Name's Suri. In every love story, I matter more than the heroine does – nobody knows that truth. And now look at me – stuck in the pocket of a guy who won't even talk.]

He sighs, very dramatic, and slips back inside.

SCENE 2 – HER, TWICE, ALMOST

EXT. SAME LOCATION – ANOTHER DAY (FIRST SIGHTING)

MEERA, 21, walks into frame. The opposite of him in every way – energetic, curious, always mid-motion. On a phone call, laughing loudly, entirely somewhere else in her head.

She doesn't even clock the bench, let alone the boy on it. Walks straight through the frame and out the other side, still laughing at whatever the phone just said.

Arjun looks up anyway. Watches her go without really meaning to. Goes back to his notebook a second later, like it didn't happen. Which, as far as she's concerned, it didn't.

A small, unimpressed noise from the pocket.

SURI (TO CAMERA)

Idi movie ayithe, ee scene ni editor already cut chesi untadu. Heroine vachindi, poyindi, hero gamaninchaledu – idi love story kaadu, oka raayi meeda documentary.

[If this were a real movie, the editor would've already cut this scene. The heroine came, went, the hero didn't even notice – this isn't a love story, it's a documentary about a rock.]

EXT. SAME LOCATION – A FEW DAYS LATER (SECOND SIGHTING)

Meera again – different day, same restless energy, phone away this time. She slows without quite meaning to. Something about the place snags her attention.

She stops. Looks around. Clocks the view. Smiles. Then clocks Arjun – actually clocks him this time.

Their eyes meet. A beat. Arjun looks away first. Meera smiles a little, not sure why. She walks on anyway – but slower than she needs to.

Arjun watches her go. Opens his notebook again. This time, he isn't writing.

A low whistle from the pocket.

SURI (TO CAMERA)

Aha. Ippude scene modalaindi. Ee ammayi flute kaadu, guitar kaadu – straight-up love song entry idi. Naaku ippude telusu, ee cinema lo naaku pani pettabothunnaru ani.

[Ooh. Now a scene's starting. This girl isn't a flute, isn't a guitar – straight-up love-song entry. I already know I'm getting put to work in this film.]

He clicks his tongue.

SURI (TO CAMERA)

Kaani ee abbayi ni chusthe, nenu retirement teesukovalsi vastundemo anipistundi.

[But looking at this guy, I have a feeling I might need to take early retirement.]

A beat. Then, almost to himself, more honest than his usual bragging:

SURI (TO CAMERA)

Nijam cheppali ante, naaku ekkuva em kaavalsindi ledu. Award vaddu, fame vaddu, paatalu paadalani kuda ledu. Nannu vaadalani kuda ledu. Kaavalsindi okkate – vaadu evaritho aina, oka sari, dhairyanga

maatladatam. Adi chusthe chalu naaku.

[Honestly, I don't need much. Not an award, not fame, I'm not even asking to sing. I don't even want to be played. I just want one thing – to see him talk to someone, bravely, just once. That's enough for me.]

SCENE 3 – RAIN

EXT. SAME LOCATION – EVENING (THIRD TIME)

Dark clouds. Wind picking up. Arjun sits alone. A drop of rain lands on his hand. Then another. He shuts the notebook, tucks it carefully under his arm, out of the weather – a habit that looks old, practiced. The rain turns heavy, fast.

Before he can leave – MEERA comes running into frame, soaked, laughing, hunting for shelter. She spots the little roof near Arjun and ducks under it. Both of them drenched. A beat of silence – the kind two people share when they've technically met before, just never like this.

Meera catches her breath. Notices, for the first time up close, the notebook still clutched against his chest like it matters more than staying dry.

MEERA

(easy, curious, fluent Hindi)

Yeh kitaab jo hamesha aapke paas hoti hai – ismein
kya likhte hain aap?

[That book you always have with you – what do you write in it?]

Arjun looks at her. Understands maybe a third of the sentence, and freezes on the rest. Says nothing. Not rude – just genuinely stuck.

Meera waits a beat. Tries again, a little slower, assuming he just didn't hear her over the rain.

MEERA

Hello? Sun rahe hain aap?

[Hello? Are you listening?]

Still nothing. He looks almost apologetic about it, which somehow makes it worse.

Meera frowns, recalibrates – tries the one language she assumes is safe common ground.

MEERA

(switching, fluent English)

Can you understand me at all?

ARJUN

*(careful, effortful, relieved to finally
have something he can say)*
Little... little English.

Something clicks for Meera – not irritation, just recalculation.

MEERA
(softer now, slower)
Oh. You don't really speak Hindi, do you?

ARJUN
Little.

A beat. Neither of them quite knows what to do with that, so for a moment they just stand there, drenched, listening to the rain instead of each other.

MEERA
(trying again, simpler this time)
Rain.

ARJUN
(relieved, almost smiling)
Yes. Rain.

It isn't much. But it's the first full exchange either of them has actually landed, and they both seem to notice it at the same time.

MEERA
I'm Meera.

ARJUN
*(a beat, like he's checking the word is
safe to use)*
Arjun.

MEERA
Arjun.

She says it back, testing the shape of it. He doesn't smile, exactly – but something near it.

They don't exchange numbers. They don't make any plans. She doesn't ask what's in the notebook again, and he doesn't offer. The rain thins out, eventually, and they just... stand there a little longer than the weather requires, before she finally jogs off toward wherever she was headed in the first place.

Arjun watches her go. Opens the notebook. Doesn't write anything. Just holds it.

SURI (TO CAMERA)
(deadpan)
Idi enti, romance aa, waiting room aa? Ee speed ki,
pelli chesukovadam kanna prema lo padataniki ekkuva
time pattochu.

[What is this, a romance or a waiting room? At this rate, it'll take longer for them to fall in love than it usually takes people to just get married.]

SCENE 4 – THE NOTEBOOKS

EXT. SAME LOCATION – THE NEXT FEW DAYS (MONTAGE)

Nobody ever quite decides to start this. There's no conversation where either of them says the word “learn,” no agreement, no plan. It just keeps happening, the way two people who liked one rainy conversation find excuses to end up at the same bench again.

DAY 1 – Meera's back at the spot, half out of habit, half hoping. Arjun's already there, like always. She points at the sky, more to fill a silence than to teach anything.

MEERA

Aasmaan.

Arjun repeats it, botches it, gets it on the second try. Meera laughs, delighted out of all proportion to how small the moment actually is. Without really thinking about it, she writes it in the corner of his notebook – the one he finally, quietly, lets her hold for a second.

MEERA

(studying him, genuinely curious, not teasing yet)

You always this quiet? Or is it just me?

ARJUN

(a small shrug, almost a smile)

Just... quiet.

MEERA

Lucky guess. Or should I take that personally?

ARJUN

(the closest thing to a joke he's managed all week)

Little bit... both.

She laughs properly this time, surprised he had that in him. He looks almost as surprised as she does.

DAY 2 – Arjun, testing whether the game runs both ways, points at the same sky.

ARJUN

Aakasam.

Meera repeats it badly. “Aak... kaasam?” He actually laughs – first time all week. She starts a second notebook of her own that evening, without announcing it to anyone, least of all him.

Neither of them calls it lessons. It's just what happens now, some evenings, at this bench, between two people who are otherwise still mostly strangers.

DAY 3 – One earbud each. Meera plays him a Hindi film song, singing along badly on purpose, watching him for a reaction.

MEERA

(pulling the earbud out, teasing)

Do you even understand a word of this song?

ARJUN

(grinning)

Not one.

MEERA

Then why do you look so entertained?

ARJUN

You're funnier than the song.

She laughs, surprised all over again – he keeps doing that lately.

Arjun plays her an old Telugu melody in return – quieter, unsure if she'll even like it. She doesn't tease this time. Just listens, all the way through.

DAY 4 – A whole argument in gestures, about a movie. Meera's seen it four times. Arjun's never heard of it. She swears she'll make him watch it. He promises nothing – then shows up the next day with snacks anyway.

DAY 6 – A new game starts, and it's entirely Arjun's idea.

He waits till she's actually paying attention, then mutters something quick, almost to himself, in Telugu.

ARJUN

Neeku ardham kaadu.

[You wouldn't understand.]

MEERA

Wait, what? What did you just say?

ARJUN

(perfectly innocent)

Nothing.

MEERA

That was not nothing. Tell me.

He thinks about it, then deflects instead of translating.

ARJUN

Neeku enduku?

[Why do you need to know?]

MEERA

(flat)

That's not a translation. That's a whole new question.

ARJUN

(already laughing)

Is it?

MEERA

Arjun.

ARJUN

Fine. It means you wouldn't understand.

MEERA

Now you're translating?

ARJUN

Selectively.

He's properly laughing now – the kind he doesn't do in front of anyone else. Meera glares at him, arms crossed, trying so hard not to laugh –

– and loses. She's laughing too, mostly at him, a little at herself for falling for it every single time.

MEERA

One day I'm actually going to learn enough to catch you.

ARJUN

(still grinning)

That day, I stop talking again.

It turns into a habit. Some days it's one word. Some days a whole sentence, said just fast enough that she can't hold onto it. He never once tells her the real one. She never once stops asking. Somewhere along the way, actually catching him stops being the point for either of them.

DAY 7 – One word each, every day, without fail. Her book filling up with Telugu. His with Hindi. And somewhere in the margins, without either of them quite deciding to –

ARJUN + MEERA, with a little heart between the names.

Both notice it. Neither says anything.

Suri peeks out, looks at the notebook, looks at the camera.

SURI (TO CAMERA)

Rojuko word. Rojuko excuse ee iddaru kalavadaniki. Idi vocabulary kaadura – idi courtship, dictionary roopam lo.

[One word a day. One excuse a day for these two to meet. This isn't vocabulary, guys – this is courtship wearing a

SCENE 5 – THE SMALL MOMENTS

Their whole thing grows without either of them ever calling it love.

Meera talks – about films, music, her whole loud world. Arjun listens, catching maybe half the words and all of the feeling.

Sometimes Arjun starts explaining something and gets stuck. Meera waits. She never finishes his sentence for him. She just waits till he finds the words on his own. That becomes her whole way of loving him.

And sometimes – a lot of the time, actually – he doesn't get stuck at all. He says exactly what he means, fast, in Telugu, then deflects the second she asks him to translate – always the same two words, “Neeku enduku,” why do you need to know, thrown back at her like it settles anything. It never does. She catches the dodge every time and never once gets the actual sentence out of him. It becomes their smallest, dumbest little ritual – him getting away with it, her swearing she'll get him next time, both of them laughing before the argument even properly starts.

One evening, the conversation drifts to films – the way it always eventually does with her.

MEERA

(already lit up, mid-thought)

Yeh Jawaani Hai Deewani. I've probably seen it twenty times. He spends the whole film saying he never wants to stay anywhere too long – and then he does. Stays. For the one person worth it.

ARJUN

(teasing, gently)

Twenty times.

MEERA

At least. Don't judge me.

She nudges him, waiting for his turn. He hesitates – this isn't a game he's used to playing.

ARJUN

(quieter, almost shy about it)

Seeta Ramam.

MEERA

(surprised, delighted)

You've seen that?

ARJUN

Many times. There's this whole story that happens only in letters. Years of it. Saying so little.

Meaning everything.

A beat. Meera looks at him a little differently – like she's just found a room in his house she didn't know existed.

MEERA

(soft, not teasing anymore)

I wouldn't have guessed that one was yours.

ARJUN

Nobody ever does.

She laughs, but it's a fond laugh now, not a mocking one. He starts saving songs for her after that, before she's even said what she's in the mood for. They watch a film on his phone, shoulders touching, her narrating the Hindi bits under her breath so he doesn't lose the thread.

She falls asleep on the bench beside him. He quietly takes off his jacket, puts it over her shoulders. Looks at her – and for once, doesn't reach for the notebook. Just looks.

In the pocket, Suri goes uncharacteristically quiet. Then, soft, to camera:

SURI (TO CAMERA)

(gentler than usual)

Ee scene lo nenu em cheppanu. Konni scenelaki maatalu avasaram ledu.

[I'm not saying anything in this one. Some scenes don't need words.]

A beat. Then, unable to help himself:

SURI (TO CAMERA)

...Sare, okkate cheptha – idi naa career lo goppa performance. Okka maata kuda matladakunda ilanti emotion pettadam – ee scene ni award ki pampali.

[...okay, fine, one thing – this might be the best performance of my whole career. Not one word, and still this good. Somebody submit this scene for an award.]

SCENE 6 – THE FIRST FIGHT

EXT. SAME LOCATION – EVENING

Meera's mid-story about how some film ends. Arjun's quiet. Quieter than usual.

MEERA

Why don't you talk to me?

ARJUN

I am talking.

MEERA

No. You're always thinking. You never actually say anything.

A beat. Something sharper creeping into it now, an old question coming back with none of its lightness left.

MEERA

(quieter, almost hurt)

Are you even able to understand me at all? Really?

What he wants to say: "Because every time I look at you, I forget every word I know – in every language."

What actually comes out:

ARJUN

I don't know how... to say.

Meera goes quiet. She doesn't fully understand – but she understands enough. Her irritation just... goes.

From the pocket, Suri mutters to camera, almost sympathetic.

SURI (TO CAMERA)

Vaadiki maatalu telusu. Dhairyam ledi. Naakaithe rendu kavali – sur kuda, dhairyam kuda.

[He knows the words just fine. He just doesn't have the guts. Me, I need both – the tune AND the guts.]

SCENE 7 – NOTHING MUCH

EXT. SAME LOCATION – SUNSET

One evening, the conversation turns, the way it does once two people have run out of small things to say.

MEERA

(testing the water, half-teasing)

Okay, serious question. What do you actually want? Big picture. Job, dreams, all of it.

ARJUN

(an easy shrug)

Nothing, really.

MEERA

(not buying it)

Nothing.

ARJUN

I mean it. No big plan. I get by. I like this bench. I like being left alone. That's mostly the whole answer.

MEERA

(half-laughing)

That is the most boring answer I've ever heard in my life.

ARJUN

(grinning)

Thank you.

She laughs – then, without quite meaning to, gives her own answer, and the joke drops out of her voice halfway through.

MEERA

Mine's not boring. My mother stitched blouses in our front room till midnight most nights so I could sit for entrance exams instead of taking a job at sixteen. My father drove the same auto for eleven years so the gap between what we had and what I'd get to have would actually mean something.

A beat.

MEERA

So no, I don't really get to want 'nothing.'
Everything I have, someone else paid for. I owe it to actually become something.

ARJUN

(quiet, no jokes left in it)

That's not boring either.

MEERA

(a small, embarrassed laugh, waving it off)

Anyway. Depressing. Ignore me.

She reaches for his notebook – a habit by now – flips it open the wrong way, toward pages she's never seen. Stops.

MEERA

(surprised)

Wait. What is this?

She holds up a page – a careful, practiced sketch. The lake. The bench. The edge of a face that might be her own, unfinished.

ARJUN

(embarrassed, reaching for it)

It's nothing–

MEERA

(pulling it back, delighted)

This is not nothing, Arjun. This is actually good.

ARJUN

(mumbling)
It's just something I do.

MEERA
You have a whole hidden talent and 'nothing' was your big-picture answer?

ARJUN
(a small smile)
I didn't say I had no talent. I said I had no plan.

She keeps flipping, backward through the pages – past sketches, past word-lists – until she lands on a much older entry. Two words, side by side, two different hands.

"PYAAR." "PREMA."

MEERA
(quiet)
I remember this one.

ARJUN
Me too.

A long silence. They both smile. Neither says it. Not yet.

Suri, from the pocket, doesn't say anything either – for once, completely on purpose.

SCENE 8 – BOTH OF THEM, DIFFERENT NOW

EXT. SAME LOCATION – EVENING

No gap. No absence. Just time passing the way it actually does – a little at a time, mostly unnoticed, until suddenly it isn't.

Arjun's already there when Meera arrives – mid-conversation with a passing chai vendor, easy, laughing at something, gesturing like it's nothing. She stops short, watching.

MEERA
(staring)
Wait. Was that you? Talking? To a total stranger?

ARJUN
(shrugging, a little embarrassed)
People keep talking to me. I stopped being weird about it.

From the pocket, a small, delighted noise.

SURI (TO CAMERA)
Ivvala ee abbayi chai vaadi tho kuda
maatladutunnadu. Idi chusthe naaku malli pani
dorikela undi.

[Today this guy is even talking to the chai vendor. Looks like I might actually have a job again.]

MEERA

(half-laughing, still processing)

You stopped being weird about it. Just like that.

ARJUN

Not just like that. Slowly. You're not the only one who's been practicing something.

A beat. Her smile falters slightly – caught by something in that.

MEERA

(quiet)

Funny you say that.

She doesn't explain yet. Just holds it – whatever it is – a second longer.

MEERA

I don't chase things, Arjun. I never have. If something's hard, I let it go – that's just who I've been my whole life. Easier that way.

A beat.

MEERA

This time I didn't want to let go. That's new. That's... you.

ARJUN

(quiet, a small smile, the old game one more time, but honest now)

Same thing you asked me. That first day, in the rain. Remember?

MEERA

(realizing)

"Are you able to understand me at all."

He nods. Then, careful but real, in Hindi this time:

ARJUN

(fluent, steady, all the way through)

Ab samajh sakta hoon. Sirf tumhari zaban nahi – tumhe.

[Now I can understand. Not just your language – you.]

A long beat. Meera's eyes go wet, and this time she doesn't try to hide it.

ARJUN

(quiet)

Mujhe tumse kuch kehna hai.

[I need to tell you something.]

SCENE 9 – THE PROPOSALS

Meera wipes her eyes, half-laughing.

MEERA

So tell me. Properly.

Arjun stands. Doesn't perform it. Just talks – the way he's slowly learned how to.

ARJUN

(natural, unhurried)

You know why I actually loved that film you found in my notebook – the one you teased me for liking. Seeta Ramam. Everyone remembers the letters. I kept thinking about the part where he can't say any of it out loud, so he makes something instead, and just hopes it says enough.

He reaches into the notebook – further back than the sketch she already found – and carefully tears out a single page.

A drawing. The two of them, on this bench, from behind, the lake stretched out ahead of them. Dated, small, in the corner – from weeks ago.

ARJUN

I didn't know how to say this. So I made it instead.

He hands it to her.

ARJUN

Main tumhare saath rukna chahta hoon. Hamesha ke liye.

[I want to stay. With you. For always.]

Meera looks at the drawing, then at him. Her eyes are already wet – but she isn't done. This was never going to be one-sided.

MEERA

(quiet, admitting it)

You never really got why I loved that film so much. Yeh Jawaani Hai Deewani. Everyone remembers the songs. I just remember that he spends the whole thing terrified of staying anywhere too long. That used to be the most honest thing I'd ever seen in a movie.

A beat.

MEERA

The ending's not really about running, though. It's about choosing, finally, to stop.

MEERA

(a small, teasing smile breaking through)

And before you ask – no, I'm not going to say 'neeku enduku' this time. I'm actually telling you.

MEERA

Nenu ninnu preminchanu. Ide nijam.

[I loved you. This is real.]

ARJUN

(looking at her)

You already loved me. Before today.

MEERA

Before I even admitted it to myself, probably.

A long beat. Neither of them says a plain "I love you." They already said something much bigger.

Arjun reaches into his pocket – and for the first time in this entire story, takes out Suri.

Raises the mouth organ to his lips. Plays.

It isn't perfect. It wavers, catches, finds its footing halfway through – but it's a real tune, and it's his. The same melody from the old Telugu song he once played her off his earbuds, on Day 3, when he wasn't sure she'd even like it.

She did.

She does now too.

As the last note fades out, so does Suri – right there in Arjun's hand, quietly, no ceremony. No flash, no fireworks. He just... isn't there anymore. Whatever his job was, it's done.

Somewhere, unseen, one last whisper to camera:

SURI (V.O.)

Nenu chinnappudu cheppinadi gurthundha? Vaadu oka sari, dhairyanga, evaritho aina maatladatam chudalani. Ippudu chusanu. Naa pani ayipoyindi.

[Remember what I said, way back? That I just wanted to see him say something to someone, bravely, one time. Well – I saw it. My job here is done.]

SURI (V.O.)

Ippudu iddariki maatalu vachaayi. Naa avasaram ledu inka. Chivariga cheptha – naa career motham lo, veellidharu naaku best jodi. Veedkolu.

[They've both got their own words now. They don't need me anymore. For the record – out of everyone I've ever worked with, these two are the best pair of my whole career.]

Farewell.]

MEERA

(noticing his empty hand, soft)

Where did it go?

ARJUN

*(looking at his own hand, quietly thrown,
then smiling)*

I think... it finished its job.

MEERA

(laughing through tears)

You finally said it. All of it.

ARJUN

Not alone, though.

MEERA

No.

She steps in, forehead against his.

MEERA

We were never a language problem. We were a language story. And I learned mine the hard way – for you.

ARJUN

(quiet, proud)

I know. I watched.

FINAL SCENE

EXT. SAME PLACE – MONTHS LATER

Same bench. Same trees. Same sunset. Two people sit there now, talking easy – her in Hindi, him in Telugu, sometimes both at once, sometimes still getting it wrong and laughing about it.

Their old notebook sits between them. First page, two words: PYAAR. PREMA. Last page, both their handwriting:

“Somewhere between two languages, we found one feeling.”

Arjun fumbles a word, laughs at himself before she can. Meera doesn't correct him.

ARJUN

(mock-worried, already smiling)

Do you even understand what I just said?

MEERA

(not even looking up, completely certain)

Every word.

Arjun's shirt pocket is empty now. Neither of them brings it up. Some things you just carry differently, once they've done their job.

Meera rests her head on his shoulder. Camera pulls back, slow. Their voices fade out. The laughter stays.

FADE OUT.

THE END